

PHNOM PENH RESTAURANT

Historical Story Report

A Family History of Survival, Food, Community and Belonging
Vancouver, British Columbia

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1. Before the Restaurant

Long before Phnom Penh was a restaurant in Vancouver, it was home.

The Huynh family's roots run through Cambodia, Vietnam and China. Food was part of who they were for generations before anyone in the family imagined a dining room on East Georgia Street. Solange Huynh's grandfather was a well known chef in Cambodia. Her grandmother had recipes of her own. Some of what comes out of the kitchen today can be traced directly back to them. The crab roll, made with crab, pork and jicama wrapped in tofu paper, came from her grandfather. The garlic squid came from her grandmother.

None of it was designed for a restaurant. It was family knowledge, learned the way families learn: by watching, helping, tasting and remembering.

2. 1975

In 1975 the Khmer Rouge took Phnom Penh and ordered the city emptied. Solange was in her early teens. Her father decided the family had no future under the new regime, and they left.

They walked toward Vietnam. The journey took roughly a month to a month and a half, much of it through jungle. Her parents made sure their teenage daughters looked dirty and unkempt so that soldiers would pay them less attention. At one point a sister disappeared for close to ten hours, and the family was afraid she was gone for good. They found her again.

Through all of it, their mother repeated the same instruction. Stay together.

At the time, it was about survival. Decades later, it would explain how this family runs a restaurant.

3. Noodles in Vietnam

Vietnam meant starting over. Their mother, Van Hoa Huynh, had been born there, and the family's life had always crossed Vietnamese, Cambodian and Chinese cultures.

They survived in part by selling Cambodian style noodles on the street. Eventually they opened a small noodle shop.

The pattern is worth noticing. A grandfather cooked professionally in Cambodia. After losing nearly everything, the family sold noodles in Vietnam. Years later, in a country none of them had seen, they would sell noodles again.

4. Getting Out

The eldest son went first. His passage was paid for in gold. The early attempts failed. He was caught and imprisoned, and more money had to be found to get him released. In 1979 he tried again, on a fishing boat headed for Malaysia. The crossing took about a week. Some of the people on board died of illness and dehydration. He survived, and he reached Canada. An uncle made it to Vancouver as well.

The rest of the family was still in Vietnam. Solange went with her uncle to an immigration office to translate for him while he worked to sponsor his own wife and children. While she was there, she asked a Canadian officer a question of her own. When might her brother be able to sponsor the rest of them?

The officer sat with her, mapped out how everyone in the family was related, and handed her the paperwork. She remembered him for the rest of her life as Mr. Rene, from Montreal.

Approval came about three months later.

5. December 7, 1979

The family landed in Vancouver on December 7, 1979. Solange was eighteen. The Red Cross met them at the airport with clothing for a winter none of them had ever experienced.

They were safe. They also had almost nothing.

Their mother took work as a seamstress, with Solange and one of her sisters helping with the ironing. Their father, who had worked in an airport office in Vietnam, took physical labour, including gardening. Solange started looking for a job almost immediately. One of her first applications was to the Orange Julius at Pacific Centre. She did not get it.

She would spend the rest of her working life helping run one of the best known restaurants in the city.

6. Something of Our Own

After about a year of labour work, their father decided the family needed something that belonged to them. The answer, again, was food.

Their first Vancouver kitchen was a small operation in Chinatown, on the same block of East Georgia Street as the restaurant today, but on the other side of the street. It ran out of a room tied to the Vietnamese, Cambodian and Laotian community, and it was never designed to be a restaurant. It was a kitchen for neighbours. Noodles, comfort food, and whatever people needed that day.

For roughly two years it fed people. Word moved through Vancouver's growing Vietnamese and Southeast Asian communities, among families who had also arrived with very little. For anyone rebuilding a life after war and displacement, a familiar bowl of noodles is more than a meal. A smell, a flavour, a broth done the right way, and an unfamiliar city feels briefly like somewhere you belong.

It could not stay open.

Two years of regulars were left without the one place in Vancouver that cooked the food they grew up on.

7. Crossing the Street

The family did not take that as the end of it. They took it as instructions to build the real thing, on the other side of East Georgia.

They borrowed money from friends, put in their own savings, and built a legitimate restaurant. Having crossed countries to reach Vancouver, they now crossed a street. A few dozen metres. Everything changed.

They named it after the city they had walked away from.

8. 1985, and Then Expo

Phnom Penh opened in 1985. For about the first two years, nobody in the family took a salary. Every dollar went back into the restaurant and toward repaying the friends who had made it possible.

Then Expo 86 arrived and Vancouver came to Chinatown. The dining room filled and stayed full. Word travelled past the communities who had backed the family from the start and into the rest of the city.

When more space was needed, their father took over the abandoned coffee bar next door. He worked on the build himself, including the wooden wainscoting. Some of that work has been kept through every renovation since, because he was the one who installed it.

9. What Is on the Plates

Phnom Penh has never fit into a single category, and neither has the family. The menu carries Cambodian, Vietnamese and Chinese influences because all three are in the family's history. The early dishes included Cambodian amok, dry noodles, the crab rolls that came from a grandfather's kitchen in Cambodia, and the garlic squid from a grandmother's recipe.

Over the years the deep fried chicken wings, butter beef and beef luc lac became dishes people cross the city for. Food that once connected refugees to a place they remembered became part of how Vancouver eats.

10. Stay Together

For more than a decade the family ran a second Phnom Penh on Broadway. It did well. They could have kept expanding. Instead, they chose to get smaller.

When the Broadway lease came up, their mother wanted everyone in one place. The family closed it and came back to East Georgia Street. As a business decision it was unusual. As a family decision it was the only one available. The instruction that had carried them out of Cambodia had become the way they run a restaurant.

11. Three Generations, on Both Sides of the Table

The founding generation has stepped back from the daily work. Their children carried it forward, and now their grandchildren are in the kitchen. Huu Duc Huynh is Executive Chef. His son Murray is the third generation, and he talks about wanting Phnom Penh to last another eighty or ninety years.

The same thing has been happening at the tables. Customers who were brought here as children now bring children of their own. Some families are on their third or fourth generation of eating in this room.

12. Chinatown

Phnom Penh cannot be separated from Chinatown. The chicken, the seafood and the vegetables come from businesses a short walk away. The restaurant grew up inside a neighbourhood of family businesses, grocers, butchers and fishmongers. After four decades, it is part of that history rather than a tenant in it.

13. Recognition, and What Did Not Change

When the Michelin Guide came to Vancouver, Phnom Penh was awarded a Bib Gourmand. Nearly forty years earlier, the same family's cooking had been coming out of a borrowed room that could not stay open.

The award did not turn the place into something else. There is still a line outside. Family still works the room. The dishes people have ordered for decades are still on the menu. Murray has described walking in as feeling like stepping back in time, and that is more or less the point.

14. What Was Actually Carried

A grandfather's knowledge survived. A grandmother's recipes survived. The memory of Cambodia survived. The improvisation it took to sell noodles on a street in Vietnam survived. The nerve it took to start over in Vancouver survived. And the instruction survived. Stay together.

15. The Table Is Still Set

This story can be told in dates. 1975. 1979. 1985. 1986. The dates do not explain why the place matters.

Somewhere across the street was the first attempt. A borrowed room, a pot of noodles, and people who had just arrived from somewhere else eating something that tasted like where they came from. When it had to close, the family crossed the road and began again. Their children grew up in the dining room. Their grandchildren cook here now. Vancouver grew up alongside them.

A restaurant built by a family looking for a home became part of home for a great many other people.

More than forty years later, the food still leaves the kitchen. The family is still here. The table is still set.

The history of Phnom Penh Restaurant is usually told as the story of a beloved Vancouver restaurant that opened in Chinatown in the 1980s. That is true, but it is only the final chapter of a much longer journey. The story begins before Canada, before East Georgia Street and before the restaurant carried the name Phnom Penh. It begins with a family whose relationship with food stretches back generations - and with recipes, skills and memories that survived when almost everything else had to be left behind.

I. BEFORE VANCOUVER

Phnom Penh, Cambodia

Long before Phnom Penh was the name of a restaurant in Vancouver, it was home. The Huynh family's roots cross Cambodia, Vietnam and China. Food was already part of the family's identity generations before the Vancouver restaurant existed.

Solange Huynh has described her grandfather as a successful and well-known chef in Cambodia. Some dishes eventually served in Vancouver trace their history to this earlier generation. The family's crab roll, made with ingredients including crab, pork and jicama wrapped in tofu paper, has been attributed to her grandfather. Solange has also described the restaurant's garlic squid as originating with her grandmother.

These recipes were not originally restaurant concepts created for Vancouver diners. They belonged first to a family - knowledge learned by watching, preparing, tasting and remembering.

II. CAMBODIA CHANGES

1975

In 1975, the Khmer Rouge seized Phnom Penh and the city's residents were ordered out. Solange was in her early teens. Her father concluded that the family had no future under the new regime, and the family decided to escape Cambodia.

III. THROUGH THE JUNGLE

The Journey to Vietnam

The family fled toward Vietnam on foot. Family accounts describe the journey as approximately a month to a month and a half. They travelled through the jungle. Solange recalled that her parents deliberately made the teenage daughters look dirty and dishevelled so they would attract less attention from soldiers.

At one point, one of her sisters disappeared for approximately ten hours. The family feared they might never see her again. They eventually found one another. Solange remembers her mother repeatedly giving the children one instruction during this period: Stay together.

At the time, those words concerned survival. Decades later, Solange would connect those same words to the way the family continued to operate Phnom Penh. The family eventually crossed into Vietnam in 1975.

IV. FOOD BECOMES A WAY FORWARD

Vietnam

Vietnam became another place where the family had to rebuild. Solange's mother, Van Hoa Huynh, had been born in Vietnam, and the family's background crossed Vietnamese, Cambodian and Chinese cultures.

According to Solange's earlier account, the family survived in part by selling Cambodian-style noodles on the street. Eventually, they operated a small noodle restaurant. This continuity matters: a grandfather cooked professionally in Cambodia; after displacement the family sold noodles in Vietnam; later they would return to noodles again in Vancouver.

V. TRYING TO GET OUT

Escape from Vietnam

According to the family's account, the eldest son attempted to leave before the rest of the family. The family paid in gold to arrange his passage. Early attempts failed; he was caught and imprisoned, and money had to be paid to secure his release.

In 1979 he tried again, travelling aboard a fishing boat toward Malaysia. The journey reportedly lasted approximately one week, and some people aboard died from illness and dehydration. He survived and eventually reached Canada. An uncle also made his way to Vancouver.

VI. A CHANCE ENCOUNTER

The Immigration Officer

The rest of the family remained in Vietnam. Solange accompanied her uncle to an immigration office as a translator while he worked to sponsor his wife and children. She asked a Canadian immigration officer when her brother might be able to sponsor the rest of their immediate family.

The officer mapped out the family relationships and gave her paperwork. Solange remembered him years later as 'Mr. Rene, from Montreal.' Within approximately three months, the family received approval to come to Canada.

VII. VANCOUVER

December 7, 1979

The family arrived in Vancouver on December 7, 1979. Solange was eighteen. She remembers the Red Cross meeting them at the airport and providing clothing. They were safe, but they now had to build a life from almost nothing.

VIII. STARTING FROM THE BOTTOM

The First Years in Canada

Solange's mother worked as a seamstress, while Solange and one of her sisters helped with ironing. Her father had previously worked in an office at an airport in Vietnam; in Vancouver he did physical labour, including gardening work.

Solange has recalled looking for work almost immediately after arriving. One early attempt was an application to Orange Julius at Pacific Centre. She was not hired. In retrospect, the contrast is striking: a young refugee who could not get a food-court job would spend her life helping operate one of Vancouver's best-known restaurants.

IX. "WE HAVE TO DO SOMETHING"

The Decision to Start a Business

After roughly a year of labour work, the family's father concluded that they needed something of their own. Once again, the answer was food. This led to one of the least documented, but most important, chapters in the story: the restaurant before the restaurant.

X. ACROSS EAST GEORGIA STREET

The First Vancouver Noodle Operation

Before the formal Phnom Penh Restaurant existed, the family operated a small food business in Vancouver's Chinatown. Published accounts describe it as a small operation selling noodles and other comfort food. Solange's earlier account places it in a Vietnamese, Cambodian and Laotian community centre; the later account describes a small storefront operation on the same East Georgia block as today's Phnom Penh.

Family oral history adds an important geographic detail: the operation was across East Georgia Street from the later Phnom Penh restaurant, and the family remembers the location as being east of 239 East Georgia Street. That places the archival search on the north side of East Georgia, east of 239, rather than at the later 240/244 footprint on the south side.

The precise address and exact opening year have not yet been conclusively documented. For now, the safest dating is the early 1980s.

XI. A RESTAURANT THAT WASN'T QUITE A RESTAURANT

The Unpermitted Operation

The original Vancouver food operation was not properly permitted. The family was preparing and selling food without the municipal approvals required for a conventional restaurant. This may explain why historical directories do not identify it as a Huynh restaurant: the premises may have officially appeared as a community centre, social organization, recreational facility, or another business containing the food operation.

There is also an intriguing community recollection - not yet independently verified - that the operation was at the back of an underground or basement billiard hall across East Georgia Street. This remains a research lead, not an established fact.

XII. FOOD AS COMMUNITY

More Than a Bowl of Noodles

For approximately two years, the little operation developed a following, particularly among Vancouver's growing Vietnamese and Southeast Asian communities. For people rebuilding lives after war, displacement and migration, familiar food could mean more than nourishment: a smell, flavour or bowl of noodles could briefly make an unfamiliar city feel less unfamiliar.

XIII. THE CITY SHUTS IT DOWN

Approximately Two Years Later

Municipal authorities eventually intervened because the operation lacked the necessary permits. The City shut it down. Rather than abandon the idea, the family decided to try again - this time properly, and on the other side of East Georgia Street.

XIV. CROSSING THE STREET

The Beginning of Phnom Penh

The geographic transition is one of the most compelling elements of the story. The family's first informal operation was on the north side of East Georgia. After it closed, the restaurant that would become Phnom Penh emerged on the south side. The distance was tiny; the transformation was enormous.

The family borrowed money from friends, used their savings and committed themselves to building a legitimate restaurant. After crossing countries to reach Vancouver, they now crossed a street. On the other side, Phnom Penh would begin.

XV. PHNOM PENH

1985

The strongest evidence supports 1985 as the formal founding year of Phnom Penh Restaurant. Michelin's current listing likewise describes the family-run institution as operating since 1985. A later Michelin interview with third-generation chef Murray Huynh describes the restaurant as opening in conjunction with Expo 86; the most reasonable reconciliation is that the formal restaurant dates to 1985 while 1986 and Expo became its breakthrough period.

XVI. THE ORIGINAL STOREFRONT

Before 244 Became the Familiar Address

Today Phnom Penh is at 244 East Georgia Street. The family's historical account, however, indicates that the original restaurant occupied space next to the present restaurant and later expanded. It is therefore safer not to state that Phnom Penh simply 'opened at 244 East Georgia in 1985' until the year-by-year address history is conclusively reconstructed.

XVII. BORROWED MONEY AND NO PAYCHEQUES

The Early Struggle

Money had been borrowed from friends to make the restaurant possible. According to Solange's earlier account, for approximately the first two years family members took no salary while revenue went back into the business and toward repaying those who had helped them open it.

XVIII. EXPO 86

Vancouver Finds Phnom Penh

Expo 86 transformed Vancouver and brought enormous activity to Chinatown. Solange remembers this as a breakthrough: the restaurant became packed and word spread beyond the communities that had initially supported the family's cooking. Phnom Penh was becoming part of Vancouver's restaurant culture.

XIX. NEXT DOOR

Growing Into the Restaurant

As demand grew, the family needed more room. Solange's later account says her father took over an abandoned coffee bar next door. He personally participated in building and renovating the restaurant, including installing wooden wainscoting. The family deliberately retained some of that work through later renovations because their father had installed it himself.

XX. THE FOOD CARRIES THE JOURNEY

Cambodian, Vietnamese and Chinese Influences

Phnom Penh has never fit neatly into a single culinary category, and neither does the family's history. The menu reflects Cambodian, Vietnamese and Chinese influences. Murray Huynh recalls early dishes including Cambodian amok, dry noodles and crab rolls. The crab roll is associated with the grandfather who cooked in Cambodia; garlic squid has been attributed to a grandmother's recipe.

Over time, deep-fried chicken wings, butter beef and beef luc lac became signature dishes, alongside Cambodian-style noodles, seafood preparations, soups and rice dishes.

XXI. THE DISHES VANCOUVER MADE ITS OWN

Eventually, certain Phnom Penh dishes became part of Vancouver's culinary vocabulary. Michelin specifically highlights the chicken wings, butter beef and beef luc lac. Food that once primarily connected refugees and immigrants with places they remembered had crossed cultural boundaries; Vancouver diners developed their own memories around the same dishes.

XXII. ANOTHER PHNOM PENH

The Broadway Location

For more than a decade, the family operated a second Phnom Penh location on Broadway. It was reportedly successful. The family could have continued expanding, but instead chose to become smaller again.

XXIII. "STAY TOGETHER"

Choosing Family Over Expansion

When the Broadway lease came up, the family's mother wanted everyone together. The family consolidated back into one restaurant on East Georgia. In purely commercial terms this was unconventional; in the context of the family's history it made perfect sense. The instruction that had helped them survive the journey out of Cambodia - stay together - had become a family and business philosophy.

XXIV. THE RESTAURANT BECOMES A HOME

As the decades passed, Phnom Penh became important to families beyond the Huynhs. Parents brought children; those children grew up and brought partners and children of their own. Solange has spoken about customers spanning three or four generations, and Murray describes the same phenomenon from the third-generation perspective. The generational transition was happening on both sides of the table.

XXV. FROM REFUGE TO BELONGING

The earliest noodle operation served people looking for a connection to homes they had left behind. Decades later, Vancouver-born customers began experiencing Phnom Penh itself as something familiar: a childhood dinner, a birthday, a meal with grandparents, waiting outside on East Georgia, or a favourite dish arriving at the table. A restaurant created partly because one family missed home became part of another city's idea of home.

XXVI. THREE GENERATIONS

Passing the Kitchen Forward

The founding generation eventually stepped away from daily operations. Their children carried the restaurant forward, followed by the grandchildren. Chef Murray Huynh represents the third generation. Michelin identifies his father, Huu Duc Huynh, as Executive Chef. Murray has expressed a hope that Phnom Penh might continue for another 80 or 90 years.

XXVII. CHINATOWN

Phnom Penh's identity is inseparable from Chinatown. Murray has spoken about sourcing chicken, seafood and vegetables from businesses nearby. The restaurant developed within a larger ecosystem of family businesses, grocers, butchers, fishmongers and restaurants. After four decades, Phnom Penh itself has become part of Chinatown's history.

XXVIII. MICHELIN

Recognition Arrives

Nearly four decades after Phnom Penh began, the Michelin Guide arrived in Vancouver and awarded Phnom Penh a Bib Gourmand. The contrast is striking: the family's Vancouver restaurant history began with an unpermitted noodle operation across East Georgia Street that the City shut down; decades later, the restaurant that grew from those beginnings was being recognized internationally.

XXIX. WHAT DIDN'T CHANGE

Recognition did not turn Phnom Penh into a formal fine-dining restaurant. The room remained busy, people continued lining up, family remained deeply involved, and long-time dishes stayed on the menu. Murray has described entering the restaurant as feeling like going back in time. Continuity became part of its appeal.

XXX. WHAT PHNOM PENH ACTUALLY PRESERVED

Phnom Penh preserved more than recipes. A grandfather's knowledge survived. A grandmother's recipes survived. Memories of Cambodia survived. The improvisation required to sell noodles in Vietnam survived. The willingness to begin again in Vancouver survived. And perhaps most importantly, the idea of staying together survived.

XXXI. THE UNFINISHED CHAPTER

Finding the First Vancouver Restaurant

The precise address of the family's original Vancouver noodle operation remains unresolved. What is currently known is unusually specific: it was in Chinatown; on the same East Georgia block; across the street from the later Phnom Penh restaurant; family oral history places it east of 239 East Georgia Street; it was associated with a Vietnamese, Cambodian and Laotian community space; it sold noodles and comfort food; it operated for approximately two years; it lacked the necessary restaurant permit; and the City shut it down.

An unverified community recollection places the operation toward the rear of a basement or underground billiard hall. The exact address, organization/building name, opening date and closure date remain subjects for archival investigation.

XXXII. 244 EAST GEORGIA

The Place That Remained

Today, Phnom Penh is at 244 East Georgia Street. Somewhere across that street was the family's first uncertain attempt: an informal kitchen, noodles, new immigrants and refugees eating familiar food, and no proper restaurant permit. Then came a closure, a crossing of the street, borrowed money, family labour, expansion and successive generations. The physical distance between those beginnings was only a few dozen metres; the historical distance is enormous.

XXXIII. THE TABLE IS STILL SET

More Than Forty Years Later

Phnom Penh's story can be told through dates - 1975, 1979, 1985, 1986 - but dates do not fully explain why the restaurant matters. Its history is about what people carry when almost everything else has been lost: recipes, knowledge, memory, a way of feeding people, and one another.

The grandfather cooked in Cambodia. The family cooked noodles after fleeing to Vietnam. They cooked noodles again after arriving in Vancouver. Their first Vancouver operation was closed. They crossed East Georgia Street and tried again. Their children grew up inside the restaurant. Their grandchildren eventually entered its kitchen. Meanwhile, Vancouver grew up with them.

A restaurant created by a family searching for a new home eventually became part of home for generations of other people. More than forty years later, the food still leaves the kitchen. The family is still here. And the table is still set.

HISTORICAL RECORD

What We Can Currently Establish

Documented with strong published evidence:

- The Huynh family has Cambodian, Vietnamese and Chinese roots.
- Solange's grandfather was a successful/well-known chef in Cambodia.
- The family fled Cambodia after the Khmer Rouge takeover and travelled roughly one to one-and-a-half months to Vietnam.
- They sold Cambodian-style noodles in Vietnam and later operated a small noodle restaurant there.
- Family members escaped Vietnam during the refugee exodus; the family arrived in Vancouver in December 1979.
- The Red Cross assisted them upon arrival; Van Hoa Huynh worked as a seamstress; the father initially did gardening/labour work.
- The family established a small Vancouver noodle operation serving the Southeast Asian community for approximately two years.
- The operation lacked the necessary permit and was closed by the City; a subsequent location was opened across the street.
- Friends lent the family money to establish Phnom Penh; 1985 is the strongest documented formal founding date.
- The family initially took little/no salary while repaying debts; Expo 86 was an important breakthrough.
- The restaurant expanded into a neighbouring former coffee bar; the father personally participated in renovations.
- The family operated a second Broadway location and later returned to one restaurant.
- Multiple generations of Huynhs have operated Phnom Penh and multiple generations of customers have patronized it.
- Phnom Penh currently operates at 244 East Georgia Street and has received Michelin Bib Gourmand recognition.

Family oral history supplied during this research:

- The original unpermitted Vancouver restaurant was genuinely across East Georgia Street from the later restaurant.
- The original operation was east of 239 East Georgia Street.
- The exact year of that first operation is not currently known.

These details should be treated as valuable primary oral history while archival corroboration is pursued.

Plausible but not yet established:

- The original operation may have been located in or behind a basement billiard/social hall.
- A Vietnamese-Cambodian-Laotian mutual-aid organization identified during research may have been the community centre remembered by the family.
- The precise north-side East Georgia address remains unknown.
- The exact chronology of the early south-side storefront numbers and expansion into the present 244 East Georgia footprint remains unresolved.

PRINCIPAL SOURCES AND FULL LINKS

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